Both Ledgers

Extraction and Reciprocity in My Own Life and Writing

A self-examination prepared for Jeff Kisling, Bear Creek Meeting · October 30, 2026

Built from Jeff's own blog posts (2020–2026), the project source compilation, the 2023 Epistle, the Consolidated History of IYM(C), and Jeff's own accounts of how he has lived.

How this was made, and how to read it

You asked for two things that pull against each other, and the tension is worth naming before anything else. You asked to have your own writing searched for the places where you took more than you returned, and for the places where you gave and received in balance. And you asked for something that would convince skeptical Quakers. A document that only praised you would fail the first request. A document that only confessed would fail the second, because a skeptic reads confession without a path forward as either guilt-performance or a trap.

The argument of these pages is that the two requests are actually one. The strongest case you can put before a skeptical Friend is not a better argument about capitalism. It is a ledger you have kept on yourself, honestly, in both columns. Your 2023 Epistle closes with the line *"We must begin by changing our own lives if we hope to make a real testimony for peace and justice."* This document takes that sentence at its word.

What was read

- Thirty-six dated posts from your blog archive, 2020–2026, as compiled in *Reciprocity vs. Extraction — Source Material from Jeff's Own Writing* (October 30, 2026).
- *An Epistle to Friends Regarding Community, Mutual Aid and LANDBACK* (revised), the 2023 text as it now stands in the project.
- *A Consolidated History of Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) and a Detailed Plan for Mutual Aid Practices*, the Gemini-assembled report built from two of your earlier documents.
- Your own accounts, given in recent conversations, of the Friends Volunteer Service Mission, your 1969–72 draft objection, how you have lived materially, the Hub work-weeks, and the chain of people that led to the 2024 ceremony at Grace's grave.
- Bear Creek's own minute books, as excerpted in your *Indian Boarding School References in the Bear Creek Collection*.

Cautions carried forward

Several items in your files carry flags you set yourself. They are honored here.

- *A Dream for Our Yearly Meeting* is unpublished and not yet shared with anyone. It is described below but not quoted.
- The A.J. Standing family connection to Bear Creek is unverified. It is not claimed.
- Grace's death was reported publicly at the time and was known to West Branch Friends. Her grave was not "lost." What failed was teaching, not record-keeping. The ceremony of July 22, 2024 came about because you told Paula Palmer, who contacted an Arapaho NAGPRA officer; the park ranger Peter contributed research.
- Fox appears only with his Barbados limit stated alongside.

- Material marked as compiled by an AI model is used as a lead, and labeled where it appears.
- Your preferred term is *active objection*. It is used throughout.

Two dates are fixed here. You first met Ronnie James in February 2020, at the Wet'suwet'en vigil, as your December 2020 post records; your December 2021 post marks the "second anniversary" of that connection. The First Nation–Farmer Climate Unity March is given as September 2018, the year you corrected it to.

How the two ledgers are organized

Part One sets out the test, using your own words. Part Two is the extraction ledger: thirteen places where your life or writing drew value along a one-way channel, or inherited one. Part Three is the reciprocity ledger: thirteen places where value moved both ways and kept moving. Part Four collects what you may have missed. Part Five chooses the examples most likely to reach a skeptical Friend, and says why. Part Six takes the skeptics' objections one at a time. Part Seven offers queries. A source list closes the document.

Nothing in the extraction ledger is an accusation. Every item there is something you have already begun to see, or something your own test exposes once it is applied to you as strictly as you apply it to the Yearly Meeting.

Part One. The test

Your own definitions

The sharpest sentences on this subject in your entire body of work are your own, from the Nodes-and-Channels writing of summer 2026:

> *A one-way channel is extraction.*
>
> *Charity is vertical… Mutual aid is horizontal.*
>
> *Charity manages need. Mutual aid ends it.*

And your definition of a channel, from *How Knowledge Travels* (June 27, 2026) and *Single Sentence* (August 2026):

> *A relationship strong enough to carry knowledge across a boundary… built over years, entered by invitation, and carrying in both directions.*

These four lines are a complete test. They do not require anyone to agree with you about capitalism. They do not require the word capitalism at all. That is their strength with skeptics, and it is also what makes them dangerous to apply to yourself, because they have no exemption for good intentions.

Five questions drawn from the definitions

Every item in the ledgers that follow was weighed with the same five questions. They are offered here so that you, or any Friend, can rerun the examination and reach a different verdict.

- **Direction.** Which way does the value flow: land, labor, knowledge, money, attention, standing?
- **Return.** Does anything flow back, and is it something the other party actually wanted?
- **Duration.** Does the relationship continue after the taking, or end when the need is met?
- **Invitation.** Who opened the door? Was the channel entered by invitation, or by assumption?
- **Protocol.** Whose rules govern the exchange? A meeting that receives "according to protocols it didn't write" is, in your terms, a terminal rather than a node. The same holds for a person.

Why this test is Quaker, not imported

Skeptical Friends will say this framework comes from outside the Society. It does not. Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative)'s own Advices on Mutual Care say:

> *Each of us is both giver and receiver, ready to help and to accept help.*

That single sentence contains the whole test. It asks about direction (both ways), about return (giver and receiver), and about posture (ready to accept). It is already in the book of discipline of the Yearly Meeting you would be addressing. Woolman supplies the economic version. In *A Plea for the Poor*, he names extraction as power that:

> *demands service of another without proposing an equitable reward (Ch. 15)*

and he names the inherited form, the claim that looks legal and is not:

> *If we trace an unrighteous claim and find gifts or grants to be proved by sufficient seals and witnesses, this gives not the claimant a right, for that which is opposite to righteousness is wrong, and the nature of it must be changed before it can be right. (Ch. 13)*

Between the Advices and Woolman, there is nothing in the test that a Conservative Friend can call foreign.

Part Two. The extraction ledger

Each entry gives what the record shows, how your own test reads it, what you have already done, and what remains open. The entries move from the largest and most inherited to the smallest and most personal.

1. The ground under Bear Creek

What the record shows. Bear Creek Meeting sits in Dallas County. The Treaty of 1842 ceded the remaining Sauk and Meskwaki land in Iowa, including Dallas County, and removal to Kansas was required by October 11, 1845. The Bear Creek land entries of the 1850s were made at the federal price of $1.25 an acre, properly recorded, and silent about who had held the land before. The compiled study *A Weighty Concern*, which assembles these primary sources, puts it directly:

> *As settlers, Quakers were direct beneficiaries of this process of removal. The land upon which our meetings were established was made available only through the dispossession of its original inhabitants.*

(That sentence comes from a document generated with an AI model from real sources. The facts it rests on are primary; the sentence itself is not your voice and should be attributed accordingly if used.)

How your test reads it. Direction: land flowed from Sauk and Meskwaki nations to settlers. Return: none that the Meeting's record shows. Duration: the benefit continues every First Day the meetinghouse is used. Invitation: none. Protocol: federal treaty and land office, written by one party. This is the textbook case of Woolman's Chapter 13, a claim proved by seals and witnesses that does not thereby become right.

Your share in it. You grew up in Bear Creek Meeting. The formation you value most — physical labor, communal accountability, the conscientious objectors among your elders — happened on that ground. You are not a bystander to this item. You are one of its beneficiaries, as every member is.

What you have done. You have named it publicly, worked to make the Meeting take it up, and formulated a conscientious objection to continuing as a member "as we are" until the Meeting takes up LANDBACK and ongoing engagement with Indigenous-led work.

What remains. The Meeting holds property. A Rural Resilience Hub argument that does not begin with this item will be heard as asking Indigenous partners to bless land the Meeting has not yet reckoned with.

2. The school that formed you, and what it did not teach

What the record shows. Scattergood Friends School, class of 1970. Two miles from Scattergood stood the West Branch Industrial School. The figures your research gathered are stark: the federal government paid $167 a year for the keep of each Indian child sent there. In

1886, seventy-five Indian children and thirteen white children were enrolled. Grace, an Arapaho girl, died there and was buried in the Friends' section of the West Branch cemetery. Her death was reported publicly at the time and known to Friends in West Branch.

Your own words, from *Scattergood and the Hub* (June 19, 2026):

> *That being the history of Quaker involvement in settler-colonialism, including with the Indian Boarding Schools. This is the glaring issue I'm being confronted with, and the root of my struggle with Quaker complicity in colonialism… I call this arc 'what did not reach us.'*

How your test reads it. This is extraction twice over. The first extraction was of children, their languages, and their labor, paid for per head. The second is an extraction of memory: a community that kept the knowledge and did not pass it on. You received an education shaped by that silence. The silence was not your choice, but the education was a benefit you carried for fifty years.

What you have done. You carried the knowledge back toward the people it belonged to (see Part Three, item 9). You stayed at Scattergood during every Hub work-week and spoke at an all-school meeting about the work, which is the channel running back into the institution that did not teach you.

What remains. Your phrase "what did not reach us" is accurate but can be read as passive, as if the knowledge failed to travel on its own. Your own channel definition says knowledge travels only through relationships strong enough to carry it. A sharper phrasing for skeptics might be: what we were not given, by people who had it.

3. Bear Creek's own minute books

What the record shows. From the Bear Creek Women's Minutes, Eleventh Month 1873, appointing three Friends:

> *Agreeably to the direction of the Yearly Meeting… to cooperate with the Yearly Meeting's committee on the cause of Indian affairs… Huldah Craven, Elmira Horner, and Margaret Allen.*

And the following year:

> *The committee on Indian affairs reported they found nothing to do.*

In the same years, the Meeting had an active Freedmen's committee corresponding with a school in Missouri. William Jasper Hadley, a Bear Creek-area schoolteacher, became superintendent of the Cheyenne Indian school in 1878 and of Chilocco Indian Industrial School in 1883, on the recommendation of Iowa Yearly Meeting's Committee on Indian Affairs.

How your test reads it. "Found nothing to do" is the purest record of a one-way relationship your files contain. Sauk and Meskwaki people had been removed from that county within living memory; Meskwaki people had bought back land in Tama County in 1857; and the committee

reported nothing to do. Meanwhile, the institution recommended its own people into the boarding-school system.

Why it belongs in your ledger. It is inherited, not personal. But it is in the books of your own monthly meeting, and you are the one who has read them. Whoever holds a record and decides what to do with it holds part of its weight.

What remains. These excerpts are the most persuasive single item you have for skeptics, because they cannot be dismissed as outside agitation. They are Bear Creek's own handwriting. They should be transcribed, dated, and placed where any Friend can read them, with permission from whoever holds the originals.

4. The evening panel of 2017

What the record shows. The Yearly Meeting's own minute book records the panel. From the Minute of 3rd Day and 4th Day Activities, 2017:

> *Our 2017 yearly meeting evening presentations began with Christina Nobiss, Donnielle Wanatee and Peter Clay offering a panel discussion on "Building Bridges with Native Americans." … Christina spoke of her role in establishing 'Indigenous Iowa' and 'Little Creek Camp' and stressed the importance of decolonizing our minds and including a true history of Native Americans in the history of all of us so that we can move forward together. Donnielle Wanatee spoke of the importance of building community, and how the history of the Meskwaki tribe and settlement teaches valuable ways to do this.*

Christina is Sikowis Nobiss. Donnielle Wanatee is Meskwaki. Peter Clay, the third panelist, spoke of what he had learned at the Oceti Sakowin Camp at Standing Rock. You were there. It was the first time you met Sikowis.

The Yearly Meeting offers financial support to those who come to speak at its annual sessions. The amounts are not in the minute, but the practice is standing, and there is no reason to think it was not followed that year.

Notice what the minute itself preserves. Sikowis did not only describe her work; she made a request. She asked Friends to include "a true history of Native Americans in the history of all of us." Donnielle Wanatee offered the Meskwaki settlement's history as a teacher in how to build community. The Yearly Meeting wrote both down. The request is in its own book.

Your own notes record what Sikowis later said of that evening and others like it: presentations to non-Native groups, including IYM(C) in 2017, left her frustrated because nothing came of them. And then the sentence that should sit at the center of any argument you make to Friends:

> *What registered was people showing up for work.*

How your test reads it. An invitation to speak is a request for labor: travel, preparation, and the emotional cost of explaining harm to the people descended from those who did it. The Yearly

Meeting received that labor. By Sikowis's account, nothing came back. That is a one-way channel, and it is a recent one, not 1873.

Your share in it. You were in the room. Your own guideline from 2022 reads:

> *Don't expect oppressed peoples to educate you. We shouldn't add to their burden.*

The 2017 panel was, structurally, Friends asking to be educated.

What you have done. You are the exception that proves the rule. Thirteen months later you walked ninety-four miles on the First Nation–Farmer Climate Unity March. Eight years later you were gutting the interior of the Healing Justice House. From the Yearly Meeting's side, nothing came of that evening. From your side, something did — slowly, and by showing up for work.

What remains. The speakers were offered financial support, as the Yearly Meeting's practice is. That matters, and it narrows the charge. The Yearly Meeting did not take their labor for nothing; it paid for the talk, recorded the request in its minutes, and then let the relationship end there. Payment closed the transaction; it did not open a channel. That is the difference between a fee and reciprocity, and it is worth saying exactly that way to Friends, because it shows the problem was never stinginess. One question remains that only you can answer: has anyone from the Yearly Meeting, including you, ever told Sikowis or Donnielle Wanatee plainly that the Meeting failed to follow through? A named failure is itself a small return. And there is one concrete thing the minute makes possible: Friends can be asked what the Yearly Meeting has done since 2017 to include "a true history of Native Americans" in its own history, as it was asked to do and as it recorded being asked.

5. Other people's words, reused

What the record shows. Your blog runs on quotation, generously attributed. But some passages have carried far more weight in your writing than their authors may know:

- The Des Moines Black Liberation Movement statement ("mutual aid is the new economy…") appears in at least six of your posts between December 2020 and May 2024, and again in the 2023 Epistle.
- Ronnie James's statement that a system "built by stolen bodies on stolen land for the benefit of a few is a system that is not repairable" appears in at least four posts, 2020–2023.
- Ronnie's private exchange with his boss ("everything I do is to further the replacing of the state…") was published in your December 2020 post.
- Sikowis Nobiss's words on ReMatriation, Nickita Longman's on landback, and Dean Spade's three elements recur across years.

How your test reads it. Words are knowledge, and knowledge is one of the things your own framework says can be extracted. Each reuse moves the authority of a Black or Indigenous organizer into a Quaker space where it strengthens your case. Direction: from them to you and your readers. Return: attribution and sometimes a link. Duration and invitation: for Ronnie,

settled. He has given his consent to your use of his words, and that consent is what turns repeated quotation into a channel rather than a withdrawal. For the Des Moines Black Liberation Movement statement, the record still does not show whether the organization knows its words became the backbone of a multi-year Quaker argument.

There is a further cost. In a Quaker meeting, quoting a Black liberation statement or an Indigenous leader lends you a standing your own words might not have. That standing is a real value, and it flows to you.

What you have done. You attribute carefully, link where you can, have built the "accomplices" language from Ronnie's usage with credit, and have Ronnie's consent. That is more than most writers do.

What remains. A simple practice would close most of this gap: before reusing a living person's words in a new piece, ask; and when a piece built on someone's words does any good, tell them, and offer whatever they would find useful in return. Your Nodes-and-Channels writing would call this keeping the channel two-way. It would also give you something rare to say to skeptics: *I asked before I quoted.*

6. Stories that belong to others

What the record shows. Your writing tells stories that are not only yours: Ronnie's leadership, Sikowis's dream of the acre, the Arapaho family's ceremony at Grace's grave, the Wet'suwet'en struggle that brought you and Ronnie together.

How your test reads it. At Grace's grave, the record is clear and good. The family members who came from Oklahoma asked you to take the photographs, because you are known for your photography. That is an invited channel, and the invitation rested on something you had built over years. It was not access you claimed; it was a skill they chose to call on. Retelling the ceremony in your own published writing is a separate act, and the invitation to photograph is not automatically an invitation to narrate. The same is true of your unpublished reflection on that day, which is why you flagged it as not yet shared.

What remains. Before any account of the ceremony reaches a Quaker audience, the family should see it. Fred Mosqueda traveled from Oklahoma for that day; he and the family are the ones who decide what of it travels further.

7. The posture in the Epistle

The 2023 Epistle is your most polished statement and the text you have refined most. Read with your own test, four sentences in it carry quiet one-way assumptions that skeptical readers — and Indigenous readers — will notice.

"White supremacy violently enforces the will of wealthy white people on the rest of us." "The rest of us" places you among those on whom the will is enforced. In material terms that is partly true: you have rented in working-class neighborhoods your whole life and never owned property or stocks. But in the terms of the Epistle itself, which names land and race, you are

also a white man descended from settlers who received Dallas County at $1.25 an acre. A skeptic will say you have placed yourself on the comfortable side of your own argument. Better to name both positions.

"Generations of white people once did so in this country." The Epistle offers white rural communities as an example of life "not based upon money." Your 2022 post makes the same move, calling mutual aid "a framework to return to the ways of life of our grandparents." But your grandparents' self-sufficient communities stood on land taken by treaty and removal within a generation of their founding. Barn-raisings among settlers were real reciprocity among settlers, resting on extraction from someone else. That is exactly the boundary George Fox's Box Meeting drew: reciprocal, deliberate, and limited to Friends. Holding up settler mutual aid without that limit invites the reader to feel nostalgic about the arrangement your Epistle is trying to undo.

"We can engage in efforts, such as Mutual Aid and LANDBACK, to build Beloved Community. To reach out to our neighbors to join us." The neighbors are invited to join *us*. In a document about horizontal relationship, the final movement is vertical: Friends as hosts, neighbors as guests. Your own experience at Des Moines Mutual Aid ran the other way. You were the one who asked to join, waited months to ask, and were welcomed only later.

"Mutual Aid cannot be done by committee or donations." This is true as a description of what mutual aid is not. But stated absolutely, it is contradicted by the work you most admire. GPAS is a 501(c)(3) that spent $53,000 on planning, rezoning, and environmental assessment for the Hub, and asks supporters for a standing monthly land tax to the Honor Native Land Fund. Des Moines Mutual Aid packed donated food. A skeptic will find this contradiction in five minutes. The sharper claim, and the one your own framework supports, is that money becomes reciprocal when it flows under the receiving community's protocols, continues over time, and comes with presence. A one-time check is charity. A monthly land tax paid by someone who also shows up with a crowbar is something else.

None of this calls for withdrawing the Epistle. It calls for a revision, and the revision would itself be a demonstration of the self-examination you are asking of the Meeting.

8. Arriving to give, unwilling to receive

What the record shows. From *What I don't know about Mutual Aid* (January 2, 2022):

> *When I arrived that first morning, apprehensive about what might happen, I was told this was Mutual Aid, which meant all of us were encouraged to take any food we wanted, ourselves. For many weeks I did not take any, but finally realized that was a mistake. It was like I wasn't really buying into the mutual part of this. I realized this when one of my new friends, in a friendly manner, asked why I wasn't taking any food. Now I do.*

How your test reads it. Refusing to receive is not extraction in the plain sense; nothing was taken. But it is the posture extraction depends on: a giver who stands above, needing nothing,

keeping the relationship one-way in the opposite direction. It keeps the standing on one side. Your own reading of it was exact: you were not buying into the mutual part.

Why it belongs here. Because it is the most common form of this failure among Friends, and you caught it in yourself. It is listed in this ledger so that the correction can be listed in the other one.

9. Pushing proposals through the Meeting's business

What the record shows. For years you brought your own proposals to Bear Creek's business process. In October 2026 you decided to step back from that, and from publishing in diffuse Quaker-audience spaces, and to redirect your energy toward person-to-person work.

How your test reads it. A proposal brought repeatedly to a body that does not take it up is a one-way channel of persuasion. You were sending; the Meeting was not receiving, and you were not receiving much from the Meeting either. That is not extraction of value, but it has the shape your framework warns about: one party writing the protocol and asking the other to accept it.

What remains. This is directly relevant to the request that produced this document. *Convincing skeptical Quakers* is, by your own definitions, a one-way channel unless it includes listening to them. Part Six takes this up.

10. Carbon

What the record shows. You lived without a car through all your working years in Indianapolis. You walked ninety-four miles along the Dakota Access Pipeline route. You have stood with people opposing pipelines from the 2018 March through the Wet'suwet'en vigil and since. Since 2017 you have driven: to Des Moines on Saturday mornings for three years, to Iowa City and Scattergood for four Hub work-weeks, to Bear Creek, and now to and from Madison. GPAS gave you gas cards for the Hub work.

How your test reads it. Burning oil is the extraction of a fossil resource, with the costs carried by people downstream and downwind — very often the same Indigenous communities whose land the pipelines cross. Your record here is far better than most Friends'. But your writing, as far as these sources show, never names your own fuel use alongside your opposition to pipelines. A skeptic who notices it first will use it against the whole argument. If you name it first, it becomes evidence of honesty instead.

11. Your working life

What the record shows. You spent most of your adult life in Indianapolis, in research on infant lung disease and development. Nothing in the sources reviewed for this document discusses that work in terms of reciprocity or extraction.

Why it is listed. Not because there is evidence of extraction, but because it is the largest stretch of your life the ledger cannot see. Medical research often depends on patients and

families, frequently from hospitals that serve low-income neighborhoods, whose samples and data travel into publications, grants, and careers. Research also returns real value: treatments, knowledge, infants who live. Which way did the value run in your own lab? You are the only one who can answer, and the answer could become one of your strongest stories either way. A skeptic who worked in a hospital or university would recognize it immediately.

12. The machines that helped compile this

What the record shows. Much of your recent archival work, including the Consolidated History of IYM(C) and the source compilation behind this document, was assembled with AI models: Gemini for the first, Claude for the second. Your own source notes already flag documents with `generated: {by: process:llm-claude/1}` frontmatter as "a source of leads, not text to reproduce as his."

How your test reads it. These systems run on data centers with heavy energy and water demands, and they were built from enormous quantities of writing, much of it used without the writers' consent. That is a knowledge extraction on a scale far beyond any quotation in your blog. It is also the newest channel in your life, and nothing in your writing yet examines it.

There is a practical side as well. The Consolidated History cites a single source, numbered "1," on nearly every claim, and that source is your own earlier writing. It describes the Underground Railroad and the Scattergood Hostel in sweeping terms, presents a bar chart whose values have no data behind them, and twice uses the word you have set aside in favor of *active objection*. A skeptical Friend who reads it closely will conclude that the argument is citing itself. Before using it with skeptics, either rebuild its key claims from primary sources or set it aside.

What remains. Naming this openly — I use these tools, here is what they cost, here is how I check what they produce — would do more for your credibility than hiding it.

13. The ground you live on now

What the record shows. You now live in Madison, Wisconsin. Your writing, as reviewed here, gives the Sauk, Meskwaki, and Ioway homelands of Iowa careful attention. It does not yet say anything about the ground under your present address.

Why it is listed. Madison sits on the homeland of the Ho-Chunk Nation, who call the place Teejop. Your own test asks the same questions of every place you draw on: whose land, what return, whose protocols. A Friend who has made land acknowledgment and LANDBACK central to his witness in Iowa will be asked, sooner or later, what he has done where he actually sleeps. You would want to have an answer before the question comes.

Part Three. The reciprocity ledger

These entries are weighed with the same five questions. They are listed because they pass the test, not because they are flattering. Several pass it only partly, and the entry says so.

1. The Friends Volunteer Service Mission, early 1970s

What the record shows. Your first experience of anything like mutual aid came in inner-city Indianapolis, in the years right after Scattergood. The Mission was all volunteer. Volunteers lived in the neighborhood. The wages earned in the first year were pooled to support each volunteer through a second year, in which each did whatever the first year in the neighborhood had led them to do.

How your test reads it. Direction: labor into the neighborhood, knowledge from it. Return: the second year's work was shaped by what the neighborhood had taught — the neighbors, in effect, wrote the protocol for year two. Duration: two years minimum, with residence, not commuting. Invitation: partial; the Mission arrived as an outside body. Protocol: the pooling of wages is a small common treasury, the same structure the Consolidated History proposes for the Yearly Meeting fifty years later.

Why it matters to skeptics. This is a Quaker program, run by Friends, decades before anyone in the Society used the phrase mutual aid. It shows the practice is not a recent political import. It also shows the one design choice that separates it from a typical service project: the second year belonged to what the first year taught.

2. Active objection to the draft, 1969–1972

What the record shows. You were drafted in 1969. You registered against your own resolve and wrote in your journal: *"Registered, but not convinced!"* You returned your registration certificate in January 1970 and broke with Selective Service entirely by letter in February 1972. Several men and their families in Bear Creek had refused participation in war and conscription in various ways; you agreed with their example completely, and you faced severe pushback from your own family for it.

How your test reads it. Conscription is the clearest instance in your life of Woolman's power that "demands service of another without proposing an equitable reward." Your refusal was the refusal of a one-way channel at the moment it was demanding the most. It also honored a channel running the other way: the example of the Bear Creek objectors, received and carried forward.

Why it belongs in this ledger. Reciprocity includes refusal. A relationship that cannot say no is not reciprocal. Your later conscientious objection to Bear Creek membership "as we are" has the same structure, and naming the line between them would help Friends see that your present stance is not new radicalism but a fifty-year pattern.

3. How you have lived materially

What the record shows. You have rented lodging in working-class neighborhoods your entire adult life and never owned a home. You lived without a car through all your working years in Indianapolis. You have never invested in stocks or bonds. When you left Indianapolis in 2017, everything you owned fit in a Prius along with your mother and father.

How your test reads it. These are refusals to accumulate. Ownership of land, investment in markets, and private vehicles are three of the main channels by which an ordinary American life draws value one way. You declined all three for decades. Woolman's line fits: "Wealth desired for its own sake obstructs the increase of virtue" (Ch. 1).

The honest limit. Renting still pays a landlord who owns land with its own history. Declining to invest does not undo the employer's or pension's investments, if there were any (that is an open question from Part Two, item 11). Simplicity reduces extraction; it does not by itself make reciprocity. Reciprocity needs a relationship. Your material life is the ground the relationships stood on.

Why it matters to skeptics. This item does more than any argument. A Friend who suspects that critics of the economy are comfortable people moralizing at others will find nothing to hold. You did not tell other people to give up what you kept.

4. Daily time on the land

What the record shows. You spend a couple of hours most days outdoors, for photography, exercise, and what you call spirit time.

How your test reads it. This is receiving: from land, light, and living things, without taking them away. The photographs return something, as attention and as a record shared with others. It is a small item, but it matters for one reason. Every reciprocal economy in your sources, from the Meskwaki to the Hub's Urban Farm, treats the land itself as a party to the relationship. Your daily practice is where that idea is already lived in your own body, before it becomes an argument.

5. Des Moines Mutual Aid, three years of Saturdays

What the record shows. You met Ronnie James in February 2020 at a Wet'suwet'en vigil and waited, through a long stretch of getting to know him, before asking whether it would be appropriate to join his work:

> *I knew it was important for allies to be careful about inviting ourselves into situations in ways that are not appropriate. Fortunately, he said yes.*

For about three years, every Saturday morning, you and about fifteen others packed boxes of donated food in a church basement in inner-city Des Moines for about sixty families, with no requirement to qualify. The program descends from the Black Panther Party's free breakfast program. And the welcome came only later:

> *But it wasn't until I'd been involved for several months that he said, "welcome to the community". Although I had invited myself to join this work, I wasn't really part of the community until that moment.*

How your test reads it. Every question passes. Direction: both ways, once you began taking food. Return: you received friendship, food, a political education, and the word "accomplice." Duration: three years, missing only one Saturday in the first three months, by your own December 2020 count. Invitation: asked for and granted. Protocol: entirely theirs. You did not bring Quaker process into the basement; you learned theirs.

The correction from Part Two. This is where the refusal to receive (Part Two, item 8) was corrected. The friend's question, "why aren't you taking any food?", is one of the best short teaching stories you have. It shows a Friend learning reciprocity by being taught it by the community he had come to help.

6. The First Nation–Farmer Climate Unity March, September 2018

What the record shows. Over eight days, a small group of Native and non-Native people walked ninety-four miles along the Dakota Access Pipeline route from Des Moines to Fort Dodge. The purpose was to share stories, so the walkers could work together afterward on things of common concern. From *Spirituality and Mutual Aid* (January 5, 2022):

> *there was the time I briefly explained Quaker worship and we spent a little time in silence, holding hands, during the First Nation Farmer Climate Unity March (2018). Each time we walked over the Dakota Access Pipeline as we walked together from Des Moines to Fort Dodge (ninety-four miles) someone would offer prayers.*

How your test reads it. This is the cleanest two-way exchange in your record. Quaker silence was offered; prayers were offered back. Stories traveled in both directions for eight days. And the channel continued: various combinations of the walkers have worked on many things since. It is your own definition of a channel almost word for word: built over days and then years, entered by invitation, carrying in both directions.

Why it matters to skeptics. It shows Quaker practice being given, not withheld, in an Indigenous-led space, and received. Many Friends fear that this work means giving up their own tradition. Here the tradition was the gift.

7. Teaching your own meeting, 2021–2022

What the record shows. In December 2021, as clerk of the Peace and Social Concerns Committee, you made a first systematic case to Friends. In January 2022 you wrote a post nearly every day for two weeks, preparing for and following a meeting-wide discussion at Bear Creek. *Mutual Aid is the Quaker way of being in the world* comes from that fortnight.

How your test reads it. Knowledge received in Des Moines was carried back to Bear Creek. That is the return half of a channel. It passes on direction and duration. It passes less clearly on reception: the Meeting heard, but did not build. Your later decision to step back reflects that.

8. Not inviting yourself in

What the record shows. The pattern runs through your record. You waited months before asking Ronnie. You waited for a welcome. You wrote the two-row wampum guideline:

> *The idea behind the two row wampum is two groups, such as Native people and white people, agree to travel together but separately. Neither interfering in the affairs of the other.*

And you wrote, of being asked to document Prairie Awakening, that the invitation came from the people involved.

How your test reads it. Invitation is one of the five questions. Your record on it is unusually strong. This restraint is the opposite of the 1870s pattern in Part Two, item 3, where Friends accepted government appointment to run other nations' affairs.

9. Grace, and knowledge returned

What the record shows. Grace, an Arapaho girl, died while a student at the West Branch Industrial School and was buried in the Friends' section of the West Branch Municipal Cemetery. Her death was publicly reported at the time and known to West Branch Friends. What had not happened was the ceremony that would let her spirit cross over. In 2024 the history reached you. You told Paula Palmer, whose ministry has long been Quakers and the boarding schools. Palmer contacted an Arapaho NAGPRA officer. The park ranger Peter contributed research. On July 22, 2024, members of Grace's family came from Oklahoma. They chose not to disinter her remains, and performed the ceremony at the grave. You were there to witness. The family members from Oklahoma asked you to take the photographs, because of your reputation as a photographer.

How your test reads it. This is knowledge flowing back to the people it was taken from, which is the exact reverse of the extraction in Part Two, item 2. Your part was small and precise: you did not lead, interpret, or speak for anyone. And the one thing you were asked to give, your photographs, was asked for by the family on the strength of a gift you had practiced for decades. Your daily hours outdoors with a camera (item 4) became, that day, something the family needed. You passed the knowledge to the next person who could carry it further, and the family decided everything that followed.

Why it matters to skeptics. It answers the most common objection — "what can one Friend actually do about history?" — with a specific act. It also models the hardest discipline: the family wrote the protocol.

Caution, from your own flags. The family's name and your unpublished reflection on that day should not appear in any piece for skeptics without the family's consent.

10. The Hub work-weeks, 2025–2026

What the record shows. The first work-week began in sub-freezing cold the first week of December 2025: four days of interior demolition at the house that will become the Healing Justice House. Three more work-weeks followed, in March, April, and May 2026. The volunteer call came through the Decolonial Repair Network: "No matter your skills, you are welcome to join in!" Scattergood offered meals and lodging to anyone coming to work, and you stayed there every time, sometimes with Jon Tesdell, your old roommate and fellow Bear Creek member. You spoke about the work at an all-school meeting. And GPAS organizers made sure volunteers had safety equipment, arranged for others to bring them lunch, and gave gas cards and other gifts.

GPAS's own visitor guidance says the space "carries a spirit and a history that asks something of you in return," and puts the protocol plainly:

> *If there is work to do, offer to help. Physical work is relationship.*

How your test reads it. Every question passes, and passes both ways. You gave labor. You received equipment, food, fuel, gifts, lodging, and the knowledge of what the house will become. The protocols were entirely GPAS's. The relationship began with an evening of listening in 2017 and continues. And Scattergood, an institution in your extraction ledger, appears here as a host, so the item also shows an institution beginning to move from one ledger to the other.

Why it matters to skeptics. It is the best answer to Sikowis's 2017 frustration: "What registered was people showing up for work." It is also the best proof that reciprocity is not sacrifice. You worked hard and were cared for in return. A skeptic expecting a story about guilty self-denial will find instead a story about being fed lunch by the people you came to help.

11. The Decolonial Repair Network

What the record shows. You serve on the planning committee of the Decolonial Repair Network, created by Sikowis Nobiss and Eric Anglada to support Great Plains Action Society.

How your test reads it. The network's purpose is to route settler support into Indigenous-led work on that work's terms. Your role is supporting, not directing. That is the node-and-terminal distinction you drew, turned to good use: the network is a node that serves another node's decisions.

What remains. It is worth recording, for yourself, what the network returns to its participants and what they return to GPAS. A planning committee can drift into the vertical shape of a board. The test should be run on it periodically.

12. Stepping back

What the record shows. In October 2026 you decided to step back from bringing your own proposals to Bear Creek's business process and from publishing in diffuse Quaker-audience spaces, to redirect your energy to person-to-person work, and to stay a member while objecting

to continuing "as we are." You chose to announce this publicly rather than through private notes to the clerk.

How your test reads it. This is the correction to Part Two, item 9. It closes a one-way channel of persuasion and opens person-to-person channels instead. It also uses the oldest Quaker form of reciprocity with a body you disagree with: you stay, you say plainly what you cannot accept, and you wait.

13. The writing itself, at its best

What the record shows. You have blogged for about ten years and see the posts as stories of hope and resilience. *Channels Into Knowledge* is built around the idea that knowledge should travel through relationship. You have been in touch with the United Panther Party about their educational work.

How your test reads it. At its best your writing is the return half of the channels in this ledger: what you received in Des Moines, on the March, and at the Hub, carried back to people who would otherwise never hear it. That is why the cautions in Part Two, items 5 and 6, matter. The writing is reciprocal when the people whose knowledge it carries know about it, consent to it, and gain from it.

Part Four. What you may have missed

The ledgers above contain the evidence. This part draws out the patterns that are easy to miss because they run across several entries at once.

1. Receiving is the half of reciprocity you have written least about

Your blog writes at length about what you gave: Saturdays, labor, testimony, demolition. It writes much less about what you received: the food at Des Moines Mutual Aid, the "welcome to the community," the silence and prayers on the March, lunches and safety equipment and gas cards from GPAS, meals and beds at Scattergood. Yet the receiving is the part that proves the relationship is horizontal. A Friend who only gives is doing charity, however radical his politics. Your own record shows you learned this in a church basement in 2020. Your writing has not caught up with your life on this point.

For skeptics this matters more than anything else in this document. Their fear is that mutual aid means endless giving by the comfortable to the needy, with guilt as the fuel. Your record says the opposite: you were fed, housed, equipped, and welcomed, and that is why the work lasted.

2. Your strongest examples are the ones where Quaker practice was the gift

On the March, you offered Quaker silence and it was received. At Scattergood, a Quaker school hosted workers for an Indigenous-led project and invited you to speak to its students. At Grace's grave, a Friend's knowledge reached the family through other Friends. In each case, Quaker tradition was not set aside or apologized for. It was given, in a channel someone else defined. Skeptical Conservative Friends often fear that decolonial work means abandoning their tradition. Your record shows it can mean offering it, on invitation.

3. Friends in your own Meeting carried a channel before you did

Your own files note that a few members of Bear Creek have spent about thirty years building relationships with the people who hold Prairie Awakening, near Earlham, a few miles from the meetinghouse. The Meeting supported them but did not build on the channel they made. That is your own Meeting's best example of reciprocity, and it predates your involvement. It may persuade Bear Creek Friends far more than anything from Des Moines or Iowa City, because it is theirs. Those Friends, not you, are the natural voices for it, and asking them is itself a reciprocal act.

4. You were in the room in 2017

Part Two, item 4, deserves to be said plainly in anything you write for the Yearly Meeting. You heard the same panel everyone else heard, and the minute records what was asked that evening. The difference between you and the rest of the body was not insight; it was that you kept showing up. That framing is humble, accurate, and hard to argue with.

5. The absolute claims in your writing are the easiest place for a skeptic to start

"Mutual Aid cannot be done by committee or donations." "There cannot be white supremacy, for example, if there is no vertical hierarchy." "Capitalism is revealed as an unjust, untenable system." These sentences are written as certainties. A skeptic who finds one counterexample — GPAS's 501(c)(3) status, a hierarchical Indigenous society, a well-fed suburb — will feel free to dismiss the rest. The reciprocity frame lets you trade certainties for questions anyone can check: which way does it flow, does it flow back, who wrote the rules?

6. "Convincing" is a one-way channel

You asked for help to convince skeptical Quakers. By your own definitions, convincing is a channel running one direction: from you, into them. A reciprocal approach would ask skeptics what they have seen, what they fear, and where they have known reciprocity themselves, and would expect to be changed by their answers. Many skeptical Conservative Friends are farmers, or the children of farmers, who have lived reciprocity at threshing time and in sickness and at funerals. They may know more about it than they know the word. The most persuasive thing you can do may be to ask them for their examples before offering yours.

7. History told as Quaker heroism can itself be extraction

The Consolidated History calls the Underground Railroad an instance of mutual aid in which Iowa Friends served as conductors and station agents. The people who bore most of the risk, planned the escapes, and walked the distance were the freedom seekers themselves. Telling the story with Friends at the center takes credit from them, which is a quiet form of extraction. The Scattergood Hostel story has a similar edge: refugees were "expected to take part in work crews," which a skeptic could read as a condition of aid rather than an expression of mutuality. Both stories are real and worth telling. Told carefully, with the agency of the freedom seekers and the refugees at the center, they persuade. Told as Quaker accomplishment, they become exactly what you are asking Friends to stop doing.

8. The language in the documents you inherited is not yet yours

The Consolidated History uses the word you have set aside, twice, including the phrase "reducing potential internal [opposition] to the shifts." It talks about IYM(C) "leveraging" assets and "strategic pillars." That is a consultant's vocabulary, not a Conservative Friend's, and it will be heard as one. Your own best sentences are plain: "I didn't take any food." "What registered was people showing up for work." Write in that register.

9. The test applies to the Hub argument too

A Rural Resilience Hub at Bear Creek could easily become a new one-way channel: Friends building something on Meeting land and inviting Indigenous partners to bless it. Your unpublished *A Dream for Our Yearly Meeting* already rejects attaching meetings to the Iowa

City acre and asks for local expressions rooted in each meeting's own ground and relationships. The five questions sharpen that: whose idea, whose protocol, what returns to whom, and does the Meeting first reckon with the ground (Part Two, item 1)? The strongest version of the proposal may begin with the Prairie Awakening relationships and with what those partners want, rather than with a design.

10. Keep a ledger, not just a testimony

Your record is full of acts but has no single place where they are recorded as exchanges: what was given, what was received, what was asked, what was returned, what is still owed. Woolman kept accounts of conscience; so did the early Meetings for Sufferings. A plain ledger, kept privately and shared when useful, would let you answer any skeptic's "what have you actually done?" with facts, and would show you, year by year, where your own channels are running one way.

Part Five. The best examples to put before skeptical Friends

These ten were chosen because each answers a specific objection, each is documented, and together they cover Quaker history, Indigenous economics, your own life, and present practice. For each: what it is, why it persuades, and the caution it needs.

1. "Each of us is both giver and receiver"

What it is. IYM(C)'s own Advices on Mutual Care.

Why it persuades. It is the Yearly Meeting's own book. No skeptic can call it imported, political, or radical. It contains the entire test in one sentence.

Use it to show that reciprocity is already Conservative Friends' stated discipline, and the only question is whether it stops at the meetinghouse door.

2. Fox's Box Meeting, 1659

What it is. George Fox asked about sixty women to meet "to see into the necessity of all Friends who was sick and weak and who was in wants." It is the oldest organized mutual aid Quakers have on record.

Why it persuades. It is foundational Quaker history, and it was reciprocal: Friends caring for Friends, everyone potentially on either side.

The caution that must travel with it. Its circle was exactly one line wide: Friends. And Fox himself, in his 1671 Barbados address, told enslaved people to "be sober & to fear God and to love their masters and mistresses," and told masters that freedom should come only "after a considerable term of years, if they have served them faithfully." Fox never called slaveholding itself unrighteous. Quoting the Box Meeting without this would be the kind of selective history the rest of your argument opposes. Used together, the two facts make the point exactly: reciprocity among ourselves, extraction toward others, at the very founding.

3. Woolman's unrighteous claim

What it is. *A Plea for the Poor*, Chapter 13: a claim proved "by sufficient seals and witnesses" does not become right; "the nature of it must be changed before it can be right."

Why it persuades. It answers "we bought the land legally" in the voice of the most respected Friend in American history, written in 1763, before the land under Bear Creek was taken.

4. Bear Creek's own minutes, 1873 and 1874

What it is. The committee on Indian affairs appointed in 1873, and its report a year later that it "found nothing to do," while the same Meeting ran an active Freedmen's committee.

Why it persuades. It is in your own Meeting's handwriting. It shows that the issue is not whether Friends cared about justice — they plainly did, for freedmen — but where the channel was open and where it was closed.

5. The Meskwaki purchase of 1857

What it is. Meskwaki people pooled their own government annuity payments and bought their first eighty acres in Tama County. That land is not a reservation granted by the federal government but privately purchased property, held as a sovereign nation.

Why it persuades. It is reciprocity as Indigenous economic practice, carried out by a nation removed from Iowa a dozen years earlier, inside the same land system that had dispossessed them. It also shows LANDBACK is not a new slogan: Meskwaki people did it themselves, with their own money, in the 1850s. *(This account comes through the compiled study* A Weighty Concern; *confirm against a Meskwaki Nation source before publishing.)*

6. "Why aren't you taking any food?"

What it is. Your own story from Des Moines Mutual Aid.

Why it persuades. It is short, self-deprecating, and true. It explains the difference between charity and mutual aid more clearly than Dean Spade's table, and it does so with a Friend as the one being corrected. Skeptics listen to a speaker who tells a story against himself.

7. The Hub work-weeks, both directions

What it is. Demolition in December cold, three more work-weeks, and in return safety gear, lunches, gas cards, gifts, and Scattergood's beds and meals.

Why it persuades. It shows reciprocity as something ordinary and practical, not heroic. It also shows a Quaker school becoming a host for Indigenous-led work fifteen miles away, which is the Rural Resilience Hub idea in miniature, already happening.

8. The March, silence and prayer

What it is. Quaker silence offered, held hands, prayers over the pipeline, and relationships that have lasted since 2018.

Why it persuades. It answers the fear that this work requires giving up Quaker practice.

9. Grace

What it is. Knowledge passed from you to Paula Palmer to an Arapaho NAGPRA officer to the family, who came from Oklahoma in July 2024 and performed the ceremony.

Why it persuades. It answers "what can one Friend do?" with a specific act, and shows a Friend serving a process the family led.

Caution. Family consent first. Accuracy about what was and was not known before. Worth telling: the family asked you to photograph because of your reputation, which shows a long-practiced gift being called on, not a Friend inserting himself.

10. Cecosesola

What it is. A Venezuelan cooperative network founded in 1967, integrating more than fifty community organizations and over 23,000 members, with about 1,300 associated workers managing daily activities "without hierarchical positions."

Why it persuades. It answers "this cannot scale." Nearly sixty years, tens of thousands of people, no hierarchy.

Caution. Use it as evidence of possibility, not as a template. Its conditions are not Iowa's.

Examples to hold back

- **The bar chart and donut chart in the Consolidated History.** They contain no data. A skeptic will notice.
- **Broad Underground Railroad claims** about Iowa Friends as a whole. Use specific, documented cases with freedom seekers' agency at the center.
- **Quotations about dismantling or destroying systems** (Ronnie's "replacing of the state," the Des Moines BLM "capitalism must be reversed and dismantled") when the audience is skeptical Conservative Friends. They are honest statements by their authors and belong in your record, but with this audience they end the conversation before the reciprocity frame can begin it.

Part Six. Meeting the skeptics

Each objection below is one you are likely to hear. The responses use your own record rather than theory. In keeping with Part Four, item 6, each also suggests a question to ask back, so that the channel runs both ways.

"This is politics, not religion."

Response. The test comes from the Advices on Mutual Care and from Woolman. "Each of us is both giver and receiver" is not a political platform. Applying it beyond the meetinghouse is what Woolman did in 1763.

Ask back. Where in your own life has help flowed both ways, and what made it work?

"Charity is a Christian and Quaker virtue. Why criticize it?"

Response. Charity is not wrong; it is incomplete. Your own Des Moines story shows the problem: when you only gave, you kept yourself above the people you came to help, without meaning to. Reciprocity keeps the generosity and removes the hierarchy.

Ask back. Have you ever been on the receiving end of charity? What did it feel like?

"We didn't take the land. People a long time ago did."

Response. Woolman's Chapter 13 answers this directly: a claim proven by seals and witnesses does not become right by being old. The benefit did not stay in the past; the Meeting uses it every week. And our own minutes record that when asked to act in 1873, the committee "found nothing to do."

Ask back. If someone today had something that once belonged to your family, would its age settle the question for you?

"Talk about capitalism drives people away."

Response. Agreed, and that is why this document hardly uses the word. You do not need to agree about economic systems to ask which way a relationship flows. Farmers who have lived through threshing rings and neighbors' harvests already know reciprocity in their bones.

Ask back. What reciprocal practices have you seen disappear in rural Iowa in your lifetime, and what replaced them?

"Mutual aid is idealistic. It can't work at scale."

Response. Cecosesola has operated for nearly sixty years with more than 23,000 members and no hierarchical positions. Closer to home, the Meskwaki Settlement has been held and governed communally since 1857.

Ask back. At what scale does your own meeting's mutual care stop working, and why?

"Quaker history is something to be proud of."

Response. Much of it is. The same record holds both: Friends who ran safe houses and Friends who ran boarding schools; a Freedmen's committee active in the same years an Indian affairs committee found nothing to do. Pride in the first does not require silence about the second. Telling both is a form of integrity.

Ask back. What did you learn about the boarding schools, and when, and from whom?

"Who are you to judge?"

Response. This is the objection this document was written to answer. You can say: I have looked at my own life with the same test. I live on settler land. I was formed in a school that did not tell me what happened two miles away. I was in the room in 2017 when the Yearly Meeting heard Sikowis and did nothing. I drive. I have sometimes quoted people before asking. I have also done some things that held up, and I learned most of them by being corrected. I am not asking anything of you I have not asked of myself.

Ask back. Would you be willing to try the five questions on one part of your own life, and tell me what you find?

"What do you actually want the Meeting to do?"

Response. Something small, specific, and continuing. Possibilities that pass the test: ask the Friends who have held the Prairie Awakening relationship for thirty years what those partners would welcome; send workers, not only money, to the next Hub work-week; consider a standing monthly contribution to the Honor Native Land Fund instead of a one-time gift; transcribe the 1873–1874 minutes and read them aloud; and before anything else, ask the Indigenous partners what they want from Bear Creek, if anything.

Ask back. What would you be willing to try for one year?

Part Seven. Queries

These are written for you first. Each can be adapted for a meeting.

- Where in my life am I still giving without receiving, and what am I protecting by doing so?
- Whose words have carried my arguments, and have I told them, asked them, or returned anything?
- Which story that I tell belongs first to someone else? Have they seen how I tell it?
- What did the work I did for most of my adult life take, and what did it give back?
- Whose homeland do I live on now, and what have I learned about its people from them, not from books?
- When I burn fuel to go and work in solidarity, what do I owe, and to whom?
- Do the tools I use to write and remember draw on people and resources without return? What would honest use look like?
- When I seek to convince, am I also willing to be convinced?
- Which of my certainties would I trade for a question my listeners could answer themselves?
- What has my own Meeting already done well, and have I said so?
- Where is a channel that someone else began, that I could help carry, without taking it over?
- What would a ledger of my last ten years show me, kept honestly in both columns?

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Items to verify before publishing anything from this document

- Family consent for any account of the July 22, 2024 ceremony.
- The Meskwaki 1857 purchase details, against a Meskwaki Nation source.
- Consent from Des Moines BLM for continued reuse of their statement. (Ronnie James's consent is in hand.)
- Permission from the holder of Bear Creek's minute books before transcription.